FARMLIFE

KCFB KINGS COUNTY FARM BUREAU

OFFICIAL MONTHLY PUBLICATION OF THE KINGS COUNTY FARM BUREAU

May 2025 Vol. 32 Number 5 kcfb.org

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April 2025 Water Policy Update: Farm Bureau Brings SGMA to the Table

by Julie Martella

April has been a month of active engagement, tough questions, and a renewed push for practical solutions as groundwater policy takes center stage in Kings County and the Tulare Lake region. Across the county, water users, from small landowners to multi-generation family farms, are watching the evolving landscape and showing up for real conversations.

Farm Bureau Leads the Conversation: Town Halls Put SGMA in the Spotlight

Groundwater policy meetings are a familiar part of life for Kings County producers. The two SGMA town hall meetings hosted by the Farm Bureau this April offered a practical forum for direct conversation. Those present represented a cross-section of local growers, ag business owners, and stakeholders seeking clear answers.

These town halls created a space where participants could ask questions, discuss challenges, and receive detailed responses from policy leaders and technical experts. While Farm Bureau is not responsible for setting policy, the organization plays a central role in bridging the communication gap between local stakeholders and those implementing SGMA requirements.

As the organization at the heart of the current lawsuit, Farm Bureau is working to ensure that local GSAs have enough time and support to develop groundwater plans that comply with the law while sustaining agriculture in the region. The goal is for the Department of Water Resources (DWR) and State Water Resources Control Board (SWRCB) to evaluate all plans and progress toward sustainability on a consistent, level playing field across the state, giving communities a fair opportunity to meet SGMA goals and keep agriculture viable.

Mid-Kings Stakeholder Advisory Committee: Shallow Well Mitigation and Beyond

In April, the Mid-Kings Stakeholder Advisory Committee focused its attention on the Shallow Well Mitigation Policy. As one of the most complex and cost-sensitive issues in groundwater management, this policy provides a framework for addressing dry wells and maintaining access to drinking water during shortages.

"SGMA" continued on page 5

Year Anniversary: State groundwater sanctions paused but Kings County farmers, water managers moving forward

By Lisa McEwen & Monserrat Solis, SJVwater.org

Wednesday, April 16th, marked one full year since the state brought the "hammer" down on Kings County farmers for pumping so much groundwater it sank a vast area that could be seen from space, nicknamed "the Corcoran bowl."

In the year since the Water Resources Control Board put the Tulare Lake subbasin on probation for lacking a plan that would, among other things, stop excessive pumping that is causing land to collapse taking an entire town with it, state actions were halted by a lawsuit, injunction and appeal.

Probation is the first enforcement step allowed under the Sustainable Groundwater Management Act (SGMA), which aims to bring overpumped aquifers into balance by 2040.

The legal actions have put a wall between Water Board staff and Kings County water managers but that doesn't mean nothing's been happening.

While state well registration, reporting and fee sanctions are on hold, just about every groundwater sustainability agency in the subbasin has implemented its own version of those measures.

A well near Corcoran pumps water into a standpipe. Lois Henry / SJV Water

Some of the region's five GSA's are even instituting penalties for exceeding pumping allocations. They are bringing farmers into the process for greater transparency. Some have contracted with the nonprofit

"Groundwater Sanctions" continued on page 7

KCFB
KINGS COUNTY FARM BUREAU

Purpose
Protect, preserve and enhance agriculture in Kings County

Vision
Ensure that every farmer has the right to farm and protect their heritage

Values
Our Members | Proactive Representative
Reliable | Trusted Resource

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KCFB Executive Director's Report

By Dusty Ference, Executive Director

Dusty Ference

April 2025 — What We've Been Working On For You

This month, we hosted our second **SGMA Informational Meeting** in Hanford to keep you updated on the Tulare Lake Subbasin and the State Water Board's probation process. We broke down what this means for you and explained how KCFB's legal efforts are aimed at protecting your access to groundwater.

We've also stayed active in meetings with state and local agencies, challenging harmful policies and ensuring Kings County farmers have a seat at the table. Your voice is being heard because we're showing up and speaking out.

Workforce Support

We've partnered with the **South Valley Industrial Collaborative (SVIC)** to tackle one of our farms' most significant challenges: finding qualified workers. We're helping connect growers to training programs and practical workforce solutions that actually work for agriculture.

KCFB also remains actively engaged with the **Kings County Economic Development Corporation (Kings EDC)** to ensure that agriculture's workforce needs are part of broader countywide planning and that agriculture is represented in regional workforce development strategies.

If hiring has been tough for you (and we know it has for many), help is on the way.

Programs That Support You

Through our partnership with the **Excelsior-Kings River Resource Conservation District**, we're helping growers tap into:

- **Free pump efficiency testing** through the WELLUP program.
- **Healthy Soils Program grants** — Round Two opens **May 1st.**

If you're considering conservation practices, now is the time to apply.

At the end of the day, **KCFB is here for one reason: you.**

Whether it's water, labor, land use, or regulation—we're proud to be in your corner, fighting for agriculture in Kings County. Thank you for your continued support of the Farm Bureau. Together, we're making a difference.

FREE Basic Pump Efficiency Class • Tuesday, June 3, 2025

The Advanced Pumping Efficiency Program (APEP) through Fresno State's Center for Irrigation Technology will provide a live in-person class on Basic Pump Efficiency on Tuesday, June 3rd at the Kings County Farm Bureau. Join us as we discuss and demonstrate pump efficiency with our Mobile Education Center (MEC) to gain an understanding of water and energy efficiency.

Basic Pump Efficiency is important from a financial, environmental, and managerial perspective. Understanding overall pump efficiency and the factors that influence a pump's condition, such as fluctuating water tables, changes in operating conditions and pump wear which all play a part in how efficiently a pump will operate. This course will demonstrate the basics of pump efficiency and the importance of performing a pump test when new equipment has been installed and periodically throughout a pump's lifecycle. In this course, we will go over three different types of pumps and the major components associated with typical agricultural and municipal pumps. We will also cover pump curves and how they are applicable to your operation.

From this class, attendees will gain knowledge on the basic components of pumps used in agricultural and municipal settings, as well as an understanding of why pumps lose efficiency. Attendees will be educated on which questions to ask of their pump tester when specifying an efficient pump based on their operation and requirements. By the end of this course, attendees will:

- Understand pump basics including pump curves, flow, total dynamic head, and overall pump efficiency (OPE).
- Determine why and when to get pumps tested.
- Explain how to match operating conditions with the correct and efficient pump.
- Specify an efficient pump using the HPin Equation.
- Calculate the cost per acre foot for electric pumps.
- Find out how to participate in APEP.

For more information on this class and other classes offered by APEP, please contact us:

Kayla Perez, Program Manager
(559) 278-5625
Anthony Gunlund,
Education Specialist
(559) 278-7623

Center for Irrigation Technology
5370 N Chestnut Ave.,
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Content for this month's "Ag News in Brief," provided by the California Farm Bureau Federation

Trump Indicates Possible Immigration Flexibility for Ag Employers, USCBP Provides No Criminal Information on January Bakersfield Arrests: At a cabinet meeting on April 10, President Trump indicated an interest in creating an avenue to legal status for agricultural employees, saying he wanted to ensure that farms and hotels with undocumented workers can continue to employ them. Meanwhile, non-profit public interest newsroom CalMatters reported on April 10 U.S. Customs and Border Protection provided no information related to prior criminal records for individuals arrested by Border Patrol agents in a high-profile enforcement action in the Bakersfield area on January 7.

UTILITIES FILE COST OF CAPITAL APPLICATIONS

On March 20, the three major utilities (Pacific Gas and Electric (PG&E), Southern California Edison (SCE), San Diego Gas and Electric (SDG&E)) and Southern California Gas (SoCalGas) filed their cost of capital applications seeking an approximately 1% increase in return on equity (ROE) in 2026.

- PG&E ROE = 10.28% requesting 11.3%;
- SCE ROE = 10.33% requesting 11.75%;
- SoCalGas ROE = 10.08% requesting 11%; and
- SDG&E ROE = 10.23% requesting 11.25%.

Many news outlets have picked up on the applications, particularly for PG&E, citing that this is another request in a long string of rate increase requests and would result in a $5.50 increase for residential customers. Agricultural customers would see a 1.4% increase on their bundled average electric service. According to PG&E's filing, the overall revenue requirement increase from PG&E's cost of capital proposal, including yield spread adjustment, is approximately $546 million. On March 25, the Chair of the Assembly Committee on Utilities and Energy Cottie Petrie-Norris along with 37 other Assembly members sent a letter to the PUC urging them to reject the request and independently analyze the requests and seek alternative financing options for capital needs. CAFB will monitor the applications and likely participate with other ratepayer groups on pushing back on the requests.

EPA SEEKING COMMENTS ON REVISED WOTUS RULE

On March 24, 2025, EPA and the Army Corps of Engineers announced a Federal Register notice requesting feedback on the implementation of the definition of "waters of the United States" in light of the U.S. Supreme Court's 2023 decision in Sackett v. Environmental Protection Agency. Feedback and recommendations are due by April 23, 2025.

SB 628 California's Ag Overtime Tax Credit

What would SB 628 do?

Senate Bill 628 would support California farmers and agricultural employees by creating a payroll tax credit to reimburse farmers for overtime wages paid to their employees. It would improve work opportunities and take-home pay for employees, delivering millions of dollars to working families and rural communities. The bill was authored by state Senator Shannon Grove, R-Bakersfield. It has bipartisan support.

Note: "Overtime wages" means the difference between the employees' overtime rate of pay and their regular rate of pay, or the "half" in "time-and-a-half."

Who supports SB 628?

California Farm Bureau, along with California farmers and ranchers support improved wages for their employees and support decisions by California policymakers to forgo General Fund revenues to reimburse agricultural employers for the cost of overtime premium wages that will flow directly to California agricultural employees and their families.

Take Action

Call and email the members of the California Senate Labor Committee https://slper.senate.ca.gov/members

These Senators will vote on Senate Bill 628 on Wednesday, April 23, 2025.

Research says overtime law has cost farmworkers $100 a week

In 2023, University of California, Berkeley, assistant professor Alexandra Hill published research showing California's 2016 agricultural overtime law had not achieved its goal of increasing earnings for farmworkers. She found that Assembly Bill 1066 caused workers to lose hours and pay as farmers shortened the workweek to balance their wage bills. Hill said her continued analysis of farmworker employment data shows farmworkers have earned roughly $100 less per week on average than they would have without AB 1066. "There is really convincing evidence that work hours for individual farmworkers fell after the law went into effect," she said.

Rising wages test ranchers who provide vegetation management

Sheep and goats, increasingly used to eat flammable vegetation in targeted areas, have become a key part of California's wildfire prevention efforts. But ranchers who provide targeted grazing services depend on a viable sheep and goat ranching industry. Their business may be in jeopardy due to a steep rise in the minimum wage ranchers must pay the herders who look after their animals around the clock. Since 2019, that wage has more than doubled, soaring this year to $4,820 a month. "It's just become untenable," said sheep rancher Andrée Soares, who operates Star Creek Land Stewards in Merced County.

Ranchers grapple with livestock losses as wolf population grows

With California wolf populations expanding and attacks on livestock on the rise, the state announced this month a new phase of managing the protected species, saying it will consider allowing more aggressive forms of nonlethal hazing to deter the predators. But frustrated ranchers say the new provisions do little to address problem wolves and their most significant cost, which is not from direct livestock kills but from stress-related impacts due to wolf presence, with cattle losing weight and failing to conceive. A new study by researchers at the University of California estimated such indirect losses at $1.4 million to $3.4 million in 2023. "This conflict is real and escalating," said Ken Tate, UC Cooperative Extension specialist. "People are not crying wolf."

Annual report shows major declines in farmland values

The value of much of California's farmland declined from 2023 to 2024, according to figures published last month by the state's chapter of the American Society of Farm Managers and Rural Appraisers. Authors of the ASFMRA chapter's annual Trends report attributed the declines in farmland value to multiple factors, including low prices for many crops, high inflation and interest rates, and overall high operating costs. Farmland subject to groundwater pumping restrictions saw some of the steepest value declines, with farmland in parts of the San Joaquin Valley that depend entirely on groundwater losing more than half its value in the space of a year.

The Kings County Farm Bureau distributes Ag News in Brief to its members only for information. Some story links may require website registration.
Opinions expressed in stories, commentaries, or editorials included in Ag News in Brief do not necessarily represent the views of the Kings County Farm Bureau.

Kings County Water District adds new member to the board

By Monserrat Solis, SJV Water

Editor's note: Monserrat Solis covers Kings County water issues for SJV Water through the California Local News Fellowship initiative.

The Kings County Water District Board of Directors unanimously appointed David Stanfield, a farm manager for Summerfield Farms and advisory member to Mid-Kings River Groundwater Sustainability Agency, to the board during its April 3 meeting.

Stanfield was one of three applicants vying for the vacant District 2 seat after director Michael Murray's resignation in March. Clif Van Groningen and John Warmerdam also threw their hats in the ring. Ultimately, Stanfield's involvement with Mid-Kings won over the board.

"I hope to see water for our ag community passed down, set up the next generation, be a good steward and serve the community," Stanfield told SJV Water.

Kings County Water District and the Mid-Kings GSA had been part of a joint powers agreement for several years as part of the region's effort to formulate a cohesive groundwater plan per the Sustainable Groundwater Management Act (SGMA).

However, the group broke apart in 2024 over disagreement on how to approach the region's plan and accusations that decisions weren't being made with enough transparency. Mid-Kings was repaired and regenerated under the Kings County Board of Supervisors. And at least one new board member on the Kings County Water District has broached the subject of rejoining with Mid-Kings.

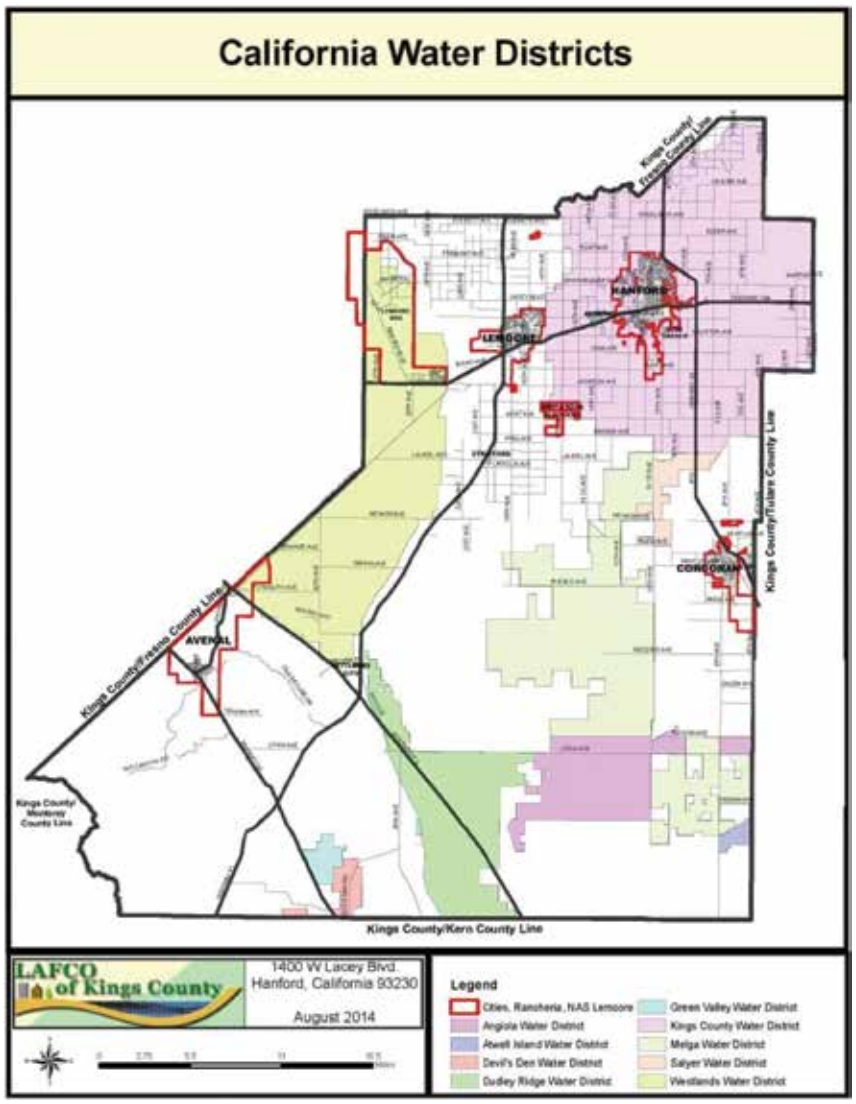
Director Chip Mello, who sits on the advisory group with Stanfield, advocated for Stanfield.

"He showed great effort to be involved in water for quite some time, and so he's up to speed with what's going on," Mello said. "I don't think the other candidates are bad. I haven't really seen them involved in the GSA and getting up to speed with what's going on there."

Stanfield was sworn in and joined the directors after the vote.

"I'm a little nervous but happy to serve," Stanfield said.

Stanfield also sits on the board for the Western Tree Nut Association, formerly the Western Agricultural Processors Association. The association represents those in the tree nut business in legislative matters.



SJV Water is an independent, nonprofit news site covering water in the San Joaquin Valley, www.sjvwater.org. Email us at sjvwater@sjvwater.org

"SGMA" continued from page 1

Key areas addressed this month included:

- **Outreach and Accessibility:** The committee reaffirmed the need for plain-language policy materials, dual-language outreach, and public workshops to ensure transparency and public engagement.
- **Eligibility and Program Entry:** The committee worked to develop recommendations that keep eligibility broad and accessible, emphasizing that all wells seeking mitigation support must be registered. Wells that failed prior to 2015 would not be eligible under the proposed framework.
- **Claims Process and Response:** The group reviewed steps for responding to well failures, recommending that drinking water be provided within 48–72 hours of a reported failure. Options discussed included temporary water delivery, well repair or replacement, and tie-ins to community wells.
- **Funding and Cost Control:** Early cost estimates were revised to just over $2 million. Funding options discussed included a volumetric pumping fee, a Prop 218 assessment, and strategies to help landowners manage mitigation solutions directly, reducing overhead and administrative costs.
- **Equity and Zone-Based Approaches:** The committee debated the merits of grid-based funding versus a basin-wide approach to ensure fairness and geographic equity, recommending continued discussion to find balanced solutions.

It's important to note that the Stakeholder Advisory Committee serves *in an advisory capacity only.* Their work is to develop recommendations for policy language, outreach strategies, and funding models. Final decisions and adoption of policy rest with the Mid-Kings GSA Board of Directors.

Tri-County Water Authority: New Allocation Policies and Subsidence Management

April saw significant policy movement from the Tri-County Water Authority (TCWA), which manages groundwater in the Tulare Lake and Tule Subbasin. The April 15 stakeholder review session focused on major policy updates to meet state requirements and address ongoing litigation concerns.

Key policy updates included:

- **Five-Year Rolling Average:** Allocations for native yield and Tier 1 transitional pumping will now be tracked on a five-year rolling basis, giving stakeholders greater planning flexibility.

"SGMA" continued on page 11

SGMA DEFENSE FUND

Join the Fight!

Kings County Farm Bureau's legal challenge against the State Water Resources Control Board has already saved growers in the Tulare Lake Sub-basin millions of dollars and kept state intervention off your farm. But the fight isn't over yet—and we need your support to finish strong. By contributing, you'll play a crucial role in securing a win for California agriculture, protecting farms, and ensuring the future of farming in California. This is a pivotal moment—your support can make all the difference.
Join us in defending California's agricultural community!

Call 559-584-3557
Email kcfb@kcfb.org
or visit our website www.kcfb.org for more information

HOW YOU CAN HELP:

$15 PER ACRE ASSESSMENT:

GROWERS IN THE TULARE SUB-BASIN
GSA ORGANIZATIONS
GROWERS OUTSIDE THE TULARE SUB-BASIN

BUSINESS SUPPORT LEVELS:

BRONZE DONOR:	$2,500
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GOLD DONOR:	$10,000
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Please make checks payable to:

Kings County Farm Bureau
870 Greenfield Ave.,
Hanford, CA
93230

Include SGMA Defense Fund on the memo line

UC Davis updates nitrogen removal coefficients for table olive

Elizabeth Fichtner, Farm Advisor, UCCE Tulare County and Daniel Geisseler, CE Specialist, UC Davis

UC Davis researchers have partnered with local UCCE Farm Advisors and industry to evaluate and update the amount of nitrogen (N) removed from orchards with the harvest of 'Manzanillo' table olives. Growers can utilize this information in the development of N management plans specific to individual orchards with the overall goal of improving N use efficiency, reducing N losses, and preserving groundwater quality.

The ratio of N applied to N removed is a key metric in the Central Valley Irrigated Lands Regulatory Program (CV-ILRP). Growers report applied N and yield to agricultural water quality coalitions. The coalitions then convert yield to quantities of N removed using crop-specific coefficients and then report estimates of N removed from orchard systems to the Central Valley Regional Water Quality Control Board. The objective of this project is to develop reliable N removal coefficients for crops grown in the Central Valley, including table olive. The project is supported by a grant from the California Department of Food and Agriculture – Fertilizer Research and Education Program (CDFA-FREP). Reports containing N removal coefficients for the crops completed so far can be found at: http://geisseler.ucdavis.edu/Project_N_Removal.html

In Tulare County, thirty-two samples of 'Manzanillo' table olives were collected from the local fruit receiving station from 2021-2023. Samples were then sent to UC Davis for analysis of total N in the Nutrient Management Lab. Nitrogen removal rates in olive fruit ranged from 5.62-8.08 lbs N/ton of fresh fruit, with an average N removal rate of 7.1 lbs N/ton of 'Manzanillo' fruit. Chico State also hosts an online tool for estimating the rate of N removal from orchards comprised of dominant oil varieties including 'Koreniki', 'Arbosana', 'Arbequina'.

Incorporating foliar nutrient analyses will allow growers to monitor the tree's nutrient status and make corrections to the fertilizer program if needed. Leaf analyses are a valuable tool to detect nutrient deficiencies but are less valuable as indicators of excess nutrient availability. Olive fruit is only an important N sink during the initial phase of growth, right after flowering. Foliar N content in July/August should range from approximately 1.3%-1.7% to maintain adequate plant health.

"Groundwater Sanctions" continued from page 1

Self-Help Enterprises to protect domestic wells.

And they've all been looking at how other subbasins have avoided state intervention.

"We are incorporating a lot of good ideas into the revised policies and revised (groundwater sustainability plan) which have been accepted in other basins and should set Mid-Kings River up for success to get out of probationary status once the lawsuit is settled," said Chuck Kinney, director of the Mid-Kings River GSA.

The Mid-Kings River GSA had to be rebuilt last year after it imploded when a key water agency pulled out of the original joint powers agreement when it was blamed for not OK'ing a groundwater plan prior to the April 16, 2024 hearing that led to probation.

A new groundwater plan should be done soon, wrote Deanna Jackson, director of the Tri-County Groundwater Authority, in an email.

Subsidence will be a key focus, she added.

"Tulare Lake region subbasins are collaborating with each other on subsidence cross boundary conditions," she wrote.

How, or whether, the state will react to the changes is unclear given the legal uncertainties, Kinney acknowledged.

"Time will tell if that pays off once we are able to have open dialogue with the state again," Kinney said.

Kings County Farm Bureau executive director Dusty Ference said the lawsuit, filed by the bureau, has "not hurt the subbasin in the slightest."

"The lawsuit is paying off," he said. "Water users have saved tremendous amounts of money not paying well registration fees and water use fees."

He referred to state probationary measures that would have required farmers put expensive meters on wells and pay an annual $300-per-well registration fee as well as $20-per-acre-foot pumped, among other fees.

Instead, farmers and local water managers are doing exactly what SGMA intended, he said, creating a plan to protect both groundwater and local agriculture.

Ference also believes the lawsuit had an impact on the outcomes of the Tule and Kern subbasin probationary hearings.

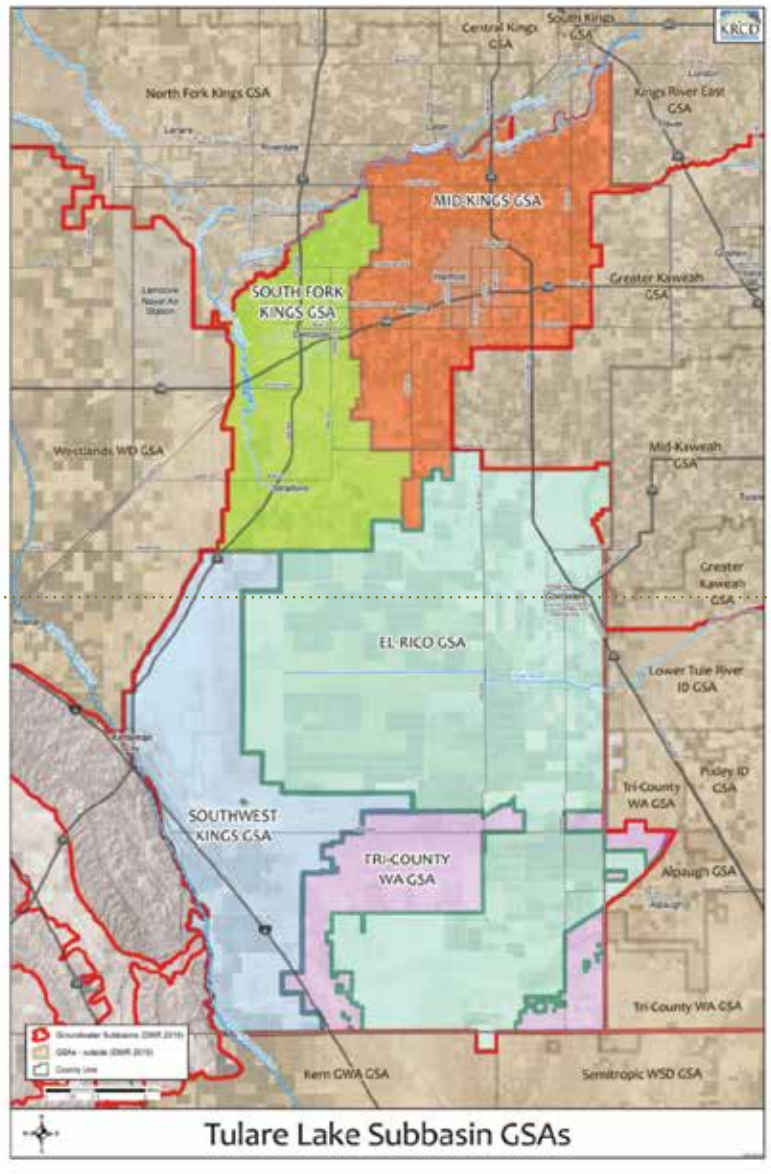
The Tule subbasin was placed on probation but two GSAs were exempted from fees and reporting based on their water accounting budgets. The Kern hearing was continued for four months to Sept. 17, 2025 to give managers time to improve their plans.

"Our lawsuit is credited at least partially for the more favorable outcomes for the Tule and Kern subbasins probationary hearings," Ference said.

Groundwater sustainability agencies in the Tulare Lake subbasin, which covers most of Kings County.

A probationary hearing for the Kaweah subbasin was canceled thanks in part to completely rewritten groundwater plan that included an aggressive, $5.8 million domestic well protection agreement with Self-Help Enterprises that protects households and small communities from impacts of lowered groundwater levels.

"We watched what was happening in the Tulare Lake subbasin, but we had our own ship with our own course and we had set sail with a direction and purpose ahead of the Tulare Lake hearing," said Aaron Fukuda, interim general manager of Mid-Kaweah GSA. "We had a lot of discussions with as many groundwater users as possible and we had to make some really difficult decisions quickly. We all agreed that we needed to do something drastic and not hold everything to perfection."



The Water Board will consider probation for three other subbasins, likely later this year. Those include the Delta-Mendota, Chowchilla and Pleasant Valley subbasins.

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EXCELSIOR/KINGS RIVER
Resource Conservation District

Healthy Soils Grant Program

Excelsior Kings River RCD will cost share projects aimed at improving on-farm soil health and on-farm composting

OBJECTIVE

Cost share healthy soils projects including but not limited to:
compost applications, mulching, cover-cropping and whole orchard recycling

SERVICE AREA

Portions of Kings, Tulare, and Fresno Counties

**Members of the Socially Disadvantaged Farmers and Ranchers (SDFR) Community are encouraged to apply and may qualify for additional funding.*

APPLICATION TIMELINE

May 1 – June 30, 2025

APPLY IN-PERSON:

Kings County Farm Bureau Office
870 Greenfield Ave., Hanford

FOR MORE INFORMATION:

www.ekrcd.org
(559) 309-4030
info@ekrcd.org

TECHNICAL ASSISTANCE AVAILABLE BY APPOINTMENT

Ag Commissioner's Compliance Report

Jimmy Hook, Agricultural Commissioner/Sealer

Bees Matter to Kings County Agriculture

When crops bloom it starts the beginning of the pollinating season. Bees are the most used pollinators in agriculture and provide an important function in farming. There are several crops grown that will not produce without the help of pollinating bees. One of those crops in this area is almonds, which we have over 35,000 acres planted in Kings County. This is one reason as to why protecting bees is important.

There are different ways to keep bees safe. Beekeepers, also known as apiary operators, play a vital role since they decide where those hives are going to be placed. When a beekeeper brings bees into the county, they are required by regulation to register and post the locations of all their hives. They can do so on BeeWhere California (beewhere.calagpermits.org). This website is where they will also list the method of notification for the beekeeper and as they are maintaining the locations of their bees, they are doing their part.

BeeWhere is not only for the beekeeper but also for the applicators. This is where applicators will perform bee checks, which is required by Title 3 California Code of Regulations (3 CCR) 6983. This regulation requires a check be done for bees within 1 mile of the site to be treated 48 hours before an application is set to be done, if using a pesticide that is labeled toxic to bees. When this is completed, the applicator will get a list of beekeepers and their preferred method of notification. The notification that the applicator gives must include the following: time and place the application is to be made; crop and acreage to be treated; method of application; active ingredient(s) and dosage rate of the pesticide to be applied; and how the person performing pest control may be contacted by the apiary operator or their designated agent. Providing this information gives the beekeeper the opportunity to move their hives if they choose to. The Kings County Agricultural Commissioner's office can help beekeepers and applicators set up accounts for registering, posting of their hives, and performing bee checks, if needed.

However, just because an applicator notifies a beekeeper of the pending application, they are not relieved of all their responsibilities. Applicators are still required to follow the labels on the pesticides they are using. All pesticides that are toxic to bees will have a statement about it under the "Environmental Hazards" section. That statement will say "This product is highly toxic to bees exposed to direct treatment or residues on blooming crops or weeds. Do not apply this product or allow it to drift to blooming crops or weeds if bees are visiting the treatment area." Which is why applicators should consider waiting until the bees are inactive to spray fields with bees in the vicinity. Bees are considered inactive from one hour after sunset to two hours before sunrise or when the temperature is below 50 degrees Fahrenheit.

Doing your part in maintaining bee safety is how we can continue to thrive as an agricultural community. If you have any questions or concerns please feel free to contact the Kings County Agricultural Commissioner's Office at 559-852-2830 or email at agstaff@co.kings.ca.us.

South Valley Industrial Collaborative (SVIC) Seeks Input from Kings County Farm Bureau Members

The South Valley Industrial Collaborative (SVIC) is committed to strengthening the regional workforce by building direct connections between employers and the education and workforce development systems. In an effort to better understand and address the unique needs of our agricultural and industrial sectors, SVIC would like to meet with Kings County Farm Bureau (KCFB) members to discuss their most critical job needs and workforce challenges.

SVIC believes that meaningful solutions start with listening. By hearing directly from employers, they aim to identify workforce gaps, skills shortages, and hiring challenges specific to the farming and agricultural industries in Kings County. This information will allow SVIC to work alongside education partners, training institutions, and workforce development organizations to craft customized strategies that respond to the needs of local employers.

S|V|I|C
#WorkingBetterTogether

If you are experiencing challenges finding skilled workers, facing recruitment issues, or anticipating future workforce needs, your input is crucial. These discussions will help shape training programs, apprenticeship opportunities, and career development initiatives that can deliver real, practical support for your operations.

To schedule a conversation about your critical job needs, please reach out to:

Matthew Hamilton, Executive Director
South Valley Industrial Collaborative (SVIC)
matt@southvalleyindustrialcollaborative.org
559-248-1926

SVIC looks forward to collaborating with Kings County's agricultural leaders to build a stronger, more sustainable workforce that supports the continued success and growth of our region's economy.

KCFB Recognizes Tony Azevedo for His Service to the Excelsior Kings River RCD

The Kings County Farm Bureau (KCFB) joins the Excelsior Kings River Resource Conservation District (EKRCD) in recognizing Tony Azevedo for his years of dedicated service and leadership on the RCD Board.

Tony played an instrumental role in guiding EKRCD through a period of rapid growth and increasing responsibility. His practical experience and strong agricultural background helped shape the District's priorities and programs, ensuring they remain focused on serving the needs of local growers and landowners.

Michael Miya, current President of the EKRCD Board, shared his appreciation: "Tony brought steady leadership and a commitment to doing what's right for agriculture and natural resource conservation. His impact will be felt for years to come."

KCFB thanks Tony for his service and applauds his continued commitment to strengthening the agricultural community and protecting the land and water we all depend on.

EXCELSIOR/KINGS RIVER
Resource Conservation District

FREE PUMP & IRRIGATION EFFICIENCY TESTING

Free tests offered to growers* in portions of Kings, Tulare, and Fresno Counties

*Members of the Socially Disadvantaged Farmers and Ranchers (SDFR) Community are encouraged to apply.
**SDFR Growers may qualify for additional pump tests and services.

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*Pump tests are provided for irrigation wells only

Kings County Rural Crime Report

This month the Rural Crimes Unit investigated the following Ag related crimes which led to several arrests.

Our biggest issues recently continue to be wire theft from ag pumps. This is costing the farmer thousands of dollars per incident to make repairs to the well pumps. There can also be a significant loss to crop production if pumps are not repaired in a timely manner. This is our top priority at this time.

Due to these reasons the Ag Unit routinely visits our local recycling business' in an attempt to locate any stolen materials (copper wire). During one of our visits, we observed several bundles of burnt AT&T wire in the recycle bins. Through this investigation, it was discovered Miguel Cervantes had been recycling AT&T wire. It is against the law to unlawfully and maliciously take down, remove, disconnect, cut, or obstruct a line of telegraph, telephone, or any line used to conduct electricity. Miguel was later located in the area of Olive Ave and Hanford Armona Rd and taken into custody. His vehicle was also towed for evidence.

We made an arrest on Williams Street in Hanford. The suspect, Jose Valdez, was also a person of interest in copper wire thefts and was interviewed. Jose provided us with valuable information concerning other local wire thefts and provided us with multiple other suspect names. We are currently attempting to identify other suspects whereabouts as we continue our wire theft investigations.

CHP was involved in a pursuit early morning on 4/22/25, with a white F-250 pickup truck and the driver was ultimately taken into custody near the 12300 block of 15th Ave. There was also a second vehicle which was involved with the Ford, which is described as a white, GMC, pickup truck. The GMC had been reported to CHP at approximately 2300 hours the day before as being stolen from Wreden Ranch (Hwy 43/Lansing Ave). The truck was stolen with a cattle trailer attached. The trailer was later located parked on the shoulder of the road just a couple of miles from the dairy site where it was originally stolen from.

At approximately 0145 hours, CHP spotted both trucks at Burger King in Lemoore which led to the pursuit of the white Ford. CHP then returned to Burger King and towed the GMC to a tow yard in Lemoore until they could notify the owner, EJ DeJong. This led us to drive to both tow yards and look at both suspect vehicles.

We looked at the GMC and noticed there was a Miller welder in the bed of the truck. This welder appeared to be nearly new and was mounted on an aluminum skid with an air compressor, torch bottles, and several reels which were later valued at $50,000. We believed this welder was stolen and began to determine the timeline in which the welder could have been stolen. We believed it was stolen in or near Lemoore once a timeline was established. We contacted LPD to ask if they had taken any reports of a stolen welder and they advised they had one stolen from inside a vacant commercial building which is being remodeled. The owner was extremely thankful we had located his welder as this welder was his livelihood.

Telecommunication wire theft has also been a big issue in the last couple of months. The Ag Unit made an arrest in March of a suspect, Hugo Mora, in Kettleman City, who was believed to be responsible for nearly all AT&T wire in our County. Since this arrest in late March, we have not had one AT&T wire theft, and he is currently still in jail.

On April 1st, an Air O Fan sprayer was stolen from the area of Highway 43 and Dover Avenue. The sprayer is described as yellow in color, approximately 500 gallons, and valued at $50,000 to replace. This sprayer is also described as custom made due to it having a 12.5' tall spray tower on the back which is used for high density crops. We are still currently looking for this sprayer. If you see one matching this description, please give us a call.

If any member would like to obtain an Owner Applied Number (OAN) please contact our Ag Unit and one will be issued to you. We can also stamp the OAN on your property at no charge if requested.

We continue to investigate Ag related thefts and encourage members to call and report all Ag related crimes. If we do not receive calls from our members and community, we may not be aware of certain crimes occurring in your area. If you have any questions, feel free to call me or any of our unit members at any time. **Detective Santos (559) 904-6893, Detective Estrada (559) 212-7512 or Investigator Ward (559) 280-5441.**

"SGMA" continued from page 5

- **Priority of Use:** The revised policies clarify the order of use of water: native yield (and carryover), landowner-developed credits (such as recharge), district-specific mitigation credits, and then transitional groundwater (Tiers 1 and 2).
- **Annual Limits and Penalties:** Clear annual limits and civil penalties are in place to keep pumping within sustainable levels, ranging from $125 to $500 per acre-foot, depending on the circumstances.
- **Subsidence Management:** The new subsidence management plan introduces adaptive thresholds tied to measured land subsidence. As certain thresholds are reached, requirements such as well registration, metering, or restricted pumping will be triggered, with higher minimum thresholds set in key zones to protect infrastructure.
- **Mapping and Compliance:** The "patchwork quilt" mapping approach recognizes differences across zones, potentially supporting fee exemptions for compliant areas.

TCWA's approach is rooted in adapting to new data and making implementation as clear and consistent as possible for stakeholders.

Stakeholder Participation: Practical Steps and Real Advice

Given the complexity and significance of these policy changes, the most valuable step any stakeholder can take is to stay engaged. Here's what you can do to remain proactive and protect your interests:

- Register every well and keep records up to date.
- Attend public workshops and committee meetings. These are your opportunities to ask questions and provide feedback.
- Review and comment on draft policies posted on your GSA website. Your input matters.
- Communicate regularly with neighbors and committee representatives to stay informed about changes and opportunities.
- Don't hesitate to ask questions. Your concerns often help identify issues that need further clarification or adjustment.

Active participation ensures that policies reflect on-the-ground realities and can help guide the direction of local water management in a way that works for the community.

Looking Ahead

With more land expected to come out of production as allocations decline, long-term stability will depend on practical planning, honest dialogue, and continued advocacy at every level. New recharge projects, surface water partnerships, and innovative funding models are all under discussion. What matters most is that local voices remain at the center of the process.

If you have questions or want to get involved, contact your committee representatives, attend a Farm Bureau event, or visit the GSA website for up-to-date draft policies and meeting information.

Julie Martella is a water consultant specializing in stakeholder engagement and SGMA compliance in the Tulare Lake Subbasin.

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If you have questions about your current sponsorship, would like to renew or join as a Friend of Farm Bureau, please contact Breanna at the KCFB office. 559-584-3557 or at blarman@kcfb.org

Kings County Farmers:

For the month of May, Ag Plastic Recycling is offering **FREE chemical jug recycling** to help you manage plastic containers easily and at no cost.

AG PLASTIC RECYCLING

BEING GOOD STEWARDS OF THE LAND, ONE BOTTLE AT A TIME.

Containers from **1 oz. to 55 gallons** are accepted in **any quantity**, as long as they are **triple rinsed** with **no caps or booklets.**

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For more information, contact Kyle Bren at 559-331-1819 or kyleb@agplasticrecycling.com

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